Youth Citizenship, Digital Activism and Electoral Mobilisation Ahead of Nigeria's 2027 General Elections

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Abstract

Digital activism enables political participation beyond elections in Nigeria. This study examines how the #TinubuMustGo campaign on X connects youth citizenship, digital activism and electoral mobilisation ahead of Nigeria's 2027 general elections. Guided by connective action theory, it uses qualitative content analysis of public posts published between 1 and 30 June 2026. Findings identify political voice, accountability demands, rights claims and agency as constructions of youth citizenship. Digital activism involves hashtag amplification, information sharing, calls to action and protest coordination. Electoral mobilisation emerges when governance concerns are linked to voting, re-election and electoral choice. However, much of the campaign remains focused on accountability and political dissent without explicit electoral appeals. The study shows how personalised grievances circulate through hashtag-mediated communication and sometimes acquire electoral significance. It contributes to African political communication research by distinguishing networked political dissent from electorally oriented mobilisation between national elections.

Keywords: Youth Citizenship, Digital Activism, Electoral Mobilisation, Connective Action, Hashtag Activism, Nigeria

Introduction

Digital media have transformed political participation across democratic and emerging democratic societies (Durotoye et al., 2026). Social networking platforms enable citizens to express political opinions, contest State policies, mobilise action and shape public discourse. In Africa, social media complement conventional political participation by enabling citizens, particularly young people, to organise protests, demand accountability and influence national conversations (Ajaegbu & Ajaegbu, 2024). In Nigeria, digital activism has characterised #OccupyNigeria (Uwalaka & Watkins, 2018), #BringBackOurGirls (Oriola, 2021), #EndSARS (Onayinka et al., 2026) and the #TinubuMustGo campaign.

Nigeria's youthful population has played a central role in digital political participation. Young Nigerians use digital platforms to discuss governance, economic conditions, insecurity and issues affecting their lives (Obia, 2025; Apata, 2025). Political participation occurs beyond elections and party activities through networked communication, hashtag activism and digitally coordinated civic action (Ugwuoke & Erubami, 2021). Through hashtags, posts, images, videos and other forms of online communication draw attention to political issues, challenge government actions, demand accountability and mobilise others (Uwalaka & Nwala, 2023). Such activism can sustain political discussion between elections and link governance concerns to future political participation (Odeyemi et al., 2022). Whether it develops an electoral orientation, however, requires closer attention.

Existing scholarship on digital activism in Nigeria has focused on protest mobilisation, online advocacy, misinformation, election campaigns and democratic participation (Obisesan, 2022). Studies of #EndSARS, have examined protest organizations (Akerele-Popoola et al., 2022), digital political narratives (Aboh, 2024), civic resistance (Adeniyi, 2022) and State responses (Dim & Chow, 2026). However, less is known about how governance and accountability concerns expressed through activism between elections connect with subsequent electoral mobilisation (Onayinka et al., 2026).

This study addresses this gap through the #TinubuMustGo campaign on X (formerly Twitter). It examines how the campaign constructs narratives of youth citizenship and political participation, the forms of digital activism evident and how governance concerns connect with electoral mobilisation ahead of Nigeria's 2027 general elections. It addresses three research questions: (1) How does the #TinubuMustGo campaign to construct narratives of youth citizenship and political participation? (2) What forms of digital activism are evident in the #TinubuMustGo campaign? (3) How does the #TinubuMustGo campaign connects governance concerns with electoral mobilisation ahead of Nigeria's 2027 general elections?

The study uses qualitative content analysis of posts containing #TinubuMustGo. Connective action theory provides a framework for examining how personalised political expressions connect through hashtag-mediated communication. The study links youth citizenship and digital activism to electoral mobilisation by examining political communication between electoral cycles.

Conceptual Framework

This study examines three concepts: youth citizenship, digital activism and electoral mobilisation. They explain how youth participation in public affairs takes the form of digital activism and how governance-related activism may acquire an electoral orientation between elections.

Youth Citizenship

Citizenship has traditionally been understood as the legal relationship between individuals and the State, encompassing rights, responsibilities and participation in public affairs (Marshall, 1950; Wood, 2022). Classical conceptions emphasised voting, political representation and civic obligations within formal democratic institutions (Dalton, 2008). Contemporary scholarship, however, extends citizenship beyond legal status to participation in civic and political life (Wood, 2022). Citizenship can therefore be practised through public deliberation, collective action, advocacy and engagement outside formal electoral institutions.

Youth citizenship concerns young people's exercise of rights and participation in public affairs (Vromen et al., 2016). Focusing on voting or party membership can overlook issue-based activism, advocacy, protest and community action. Youth engagement encompasses formal and informal political claims, public debate, accountability demands, agency and recognition (Staeheli et al., 2013). Despite formal rights, young people may have few opportunities to influence established decision-making (Harris et al., 2010). Alternative spaces let them voice claims, challenge decisions and act collectively (O'Loughlin & Gillespie, 2012).

Digital media extend youth citizenship into networked spaces (Bennett et al., 2011), where young people discuss public issues, scrutinise governments, organise around shared concerns, and circulate political information beyond traditional media and institutions (Loader et al., 2014). Using communication technologies to address public concerns can constitute citizenship (Choi, 2016), making it part of everyday political communication beyond elections (Bello & Kaufhold, 2023). However, digital citizenship is shaped by unequal internet access, misinformation, algorithmic visibility, and harassment, and does not necessarily lead to formal political action.

Digital Activism

Digital activism involves using digital technologies to communicate grievances, organise campaigns, disseminate alternative information and coordinate protest activities (George & Leidner, 2019). It covers advocacy and political discussion, protest coordination, citizen documentation, and networked mobilisation (Treré & Kaun, 2021). Digital activism may operate through formal organisations, but social media also enable decentralised participation, allowing individuals to contribute to campaigns without belonging to a

central organisation (Wang & Zhou, 2021).

Digital platforms lower barriers to political participation (Boulianne, 2020). Hashtags, livestreams, images, videos and user-generated content connect dispersed participants, circulate political claims and spotlight issues (Uwalaka and Nwala, 2023). Hashtags also aggregate contributions into searchable streams (Wang & Zhou, 2021). Digital resistance occurs when citizens use digital communication to challenge political authority, policies or dominant narratives and to organise opposition (Castillo-Esparcia et al., 2023). Digital activism also involves civic education, advocacy, information sharing, electoral discussion and mobilisation.

The political consequences of digital activism remain contested (Freelon et al., 2020; Santini & Carvalho, 2019). Low-cost forms of participation such as posting, sharing and hashtag use can expand opportunities for engagement, visibility and mobilisation, but do not necessarily lead to sustained participation or institutional change (Castillo-Esparcia et al., 2023). This study defines digital activism as digital communication for political expression, advocacy, accountability, and networked mobilisation.

Electoral Mobilisation

Electoral mobilisation refers to activities that encourage citizens to participate in electoral processes through voting, political discussion, campaign engagement and other forms of participation (Vaccari & Valeriani, 2021). Traditional mobilisation strategies have relied on political parties, campaign organisations, community leaders and conventional media (Chadwick & Stromer-Galley, 2016). Digital communication has expanded mobilisation by allowing political information, appeals and discussion to circulate outside formal campaigns (Klinger et al., 2023).

Digital platforms also make the period between elections relevant to electoral mobilisation. Citizens can discuss public policies, assess government performance, exchange political information and debate political leadership before formal campaigns begin (Odeyemi et al., 2022). Such engagement can connect everyday political concerns with electoral (Kurniawan et al., 2024). However, political discussion or exposure to electoral information should not automatically be treated as mobilisation; electoral mobilisation requires an identifiable orientation toward electoral participation.

Protest-oriented participation and electoral participation are analytically distinct, but they may intersect when grievances about governance become linked to voting, voter registration, candidate evaluation, campaign participation or other election-related actions (Masunda, 2022). Digital activism connects dissatisfaction with current political conditions to electoral participation (Uwalaka et al., 2026). This study defines electoral mobilisation as digital communication that encourages, coordinates, or directs participation in elections, including voting, registration, political choice and other engagement.

The Connective Logic of Digital Activism

Digital activism raises the question of how dispersed individuals participate in political causes without relying on formal organisations or shared collective identities (Bennett & Segerberg, 2012). Connective action theory explains this participation through personalised communication across digital networks (Bennett & Segerberg, 2023).

The theory distinguishes collective action, which generally relies on organisational coordination and shared identities, from connective action, which emerges through personalised political communication (Pond & Lewis, 2019). Bennett and Segerberg (2012) describe connective action through personalised action frames, in which participants adapt political claims to their own experiences, while remaining connected to a broader cause. Hashtags bring individual contributions into a common political discussion (Vromen, 2017).

Connective action theory is relevant to this study because #TinubuMustGo connects individual political expressions through a common hashtag. It explains how personalised posts on governance, accountability and political participation contribute to a wider digital campaign (Carson, 2021). The framework guides the analysis of how personalised grievances and political claims relate to youth citizenship and digital activism and whether these expressions acquire an electoral orientation ahead of Nigeria's 2027 general elections. An electoral orientation cannot be inferred from digital networking alone.

Contextual Literature and Research Gap

The #TinubuMustGo Campaign in Nigeria's Pre-2027 Political Environment

The period leading to Nigeria's 2027 general elections has been marked by debate over governance, economic conditions, insecurity and government accountability. Digital platforms have remained important spaces for political expression and mobilisation (Akamo, 2026). The #TinubuMustGo campaign examined in this study is situated within this pre-2027 political environment. The campaign provides a case for examining how governance-related digital activism between elections constructs narratives of youth citizenship and whether it acquires an electoral orientation ahead of 2027.

Digital Activism and Electoral Politics in Nigeria

Research on digital political participation in Nigeria has grown alongside social media use for protest, advocacy and electoral communication (Obia, 2025). #OccupyNigeria linked online communication to protests against the 2012 fuel subsidy removal (Uwalaka & Watkins, 2018). #BringBackOurGirls sustained attention to the abducted Chibok schoolgirls and connected Nigerian advocacy with transnational publics (Onah, 2024).

Studies of #EndSARS examined youth-led digital activism (Akerele-Popoola et al., 2022; Uwalaka & Nwala, 2023), including protest coordination, information sharing and citizen documentation (Uwalaka, 2024); youth political expression (Olaitan, 2024); police accountability (Abioye, 2026); participatory governance (Omilusi, 2025) and digitally networked resistance (Ilesanmi, 2025). Electoral studies examine online campaigning, political information, candidate communication and citizen engagement (Morah & Nwafor, 2024). The Obidient movement linked digital activism with the 2023 elections (Egbunike, 2025; Onayinka et al., 2026).

Studies of protest activism and electoral communication have largely developed separately, leaving inter-election political engagement less examined. Digital platforms enable discussion of government policies, accountability and leadership after elections (Boulianne, 2020), while studies of Nigerian political parties document online communication and mobilisation between elections (Odeyemi et al., 2022). X has been used for digital activism in Nigeria (Ataguba, 2026; Obia, 2025), and its searchable hashtags allow researchers to examine how grievances, accountability demands and election-related messages intersect.

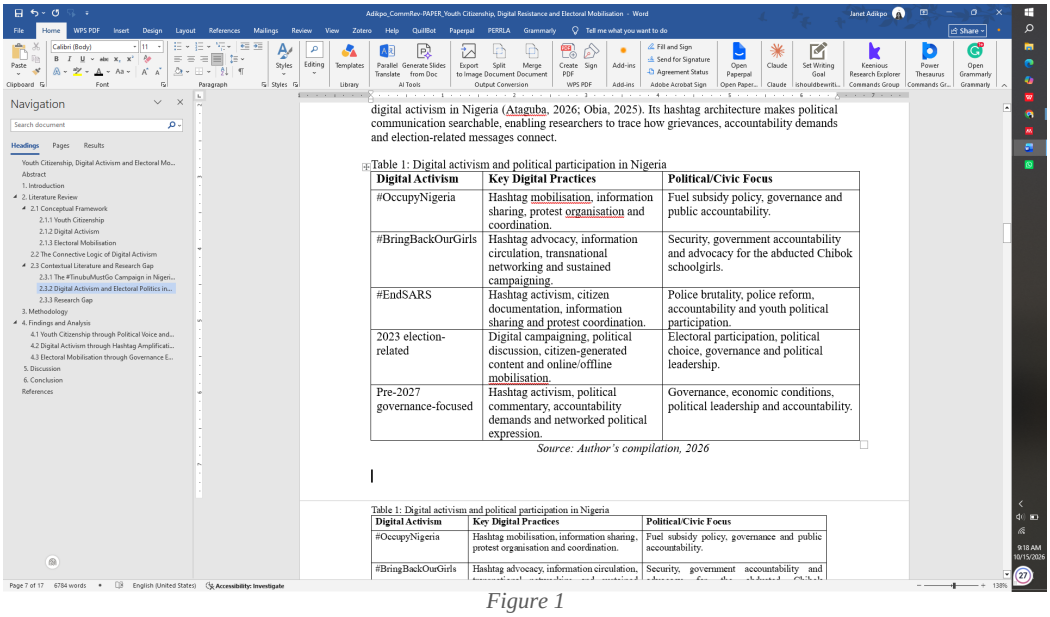


Figure 1

Research Gap

Research linking Nigerian digital activism directly to subsequent electoral mobilisation remains limited. Studies linking protest activism to electoral engagement include research on #EndSARS and the Obidient movement (Onayinka et al., 2026). However, participation in digital protest should not automatically be treated as evidence of subsequent electoral mobilisation. Existing scholarship identifies three dimensions of Nigeria's digital political environment: social media facilitate protest and civic activism (Akerele-Popoola et al., 2022; Uwalaka & Nwala, 2023); young Nigerians are prominent participants in digitally mediated political engagement (Omilusi, 2025) and digital platforms support electoral communication (Morah & Nwafor, 2024; Onayinka et al., 2026). However, the electoral orientation of governance-focused activism between elections remains underexplored. To address this gap, the study examines how #TinubuMustGo constructs narratives of youth citizenship and connects governance concerns with electoral mobilisation ahead of Nigeria's 2027 general elections.

Methodology

This study used qualitative content analysis to examine political communication within the #TinubuMustGo campaign on X (formerly Twitter). Qualitative content analysis enables systematic examination of texts to identify recurring meanings (Schreier, 2012). The analysis addressed youth citizenship and political participation, digital activism and electoral mobilisation.

The population comprised publicly accessible X posts containing the #TinubuMustGo. Posts published between 1 and 30 June 2026 were examined, situating the analysis ahead of Nigeria's 2027 general elections. Although a longer period could capture changes in political communication as the elections approached, the study focused on participation and electoral references in June 2026. Posts were retrieved using X search functions and date filters. X was selected because its public hashtag-based communication allows political messages, calls to action and electoral references to be examined together.

The #TinubuMustGo hashtag was selected as a case of digital activism centred on governance and political accountability. Its relevance lies in examining whether dissatisfaction with government performance also references electoral participation. Other political hashtags were excluded to retain focus on this campaign.

Purposive sampling was used to select publicly accessible, English-language posts relevant to the research

questions (Campbell et al., 2020). Posts were included if they used #TinubuMustGo and addressed governance, accountability, citizenship, political participation, digital activism, or electoral issues. Duplicate content, advertisements, spam, identifiable automated posts and unrelated hashtag use were excluded. Quote posts and replies were retained when they provided substantive commentary or clarified an original post's political meaning, while reposts without commentary were excluded as analytical units.

The search retrieved 74 posts, screened against these criteria, yielding 18 for analysis. Each substantive post served as the unit of analysis.

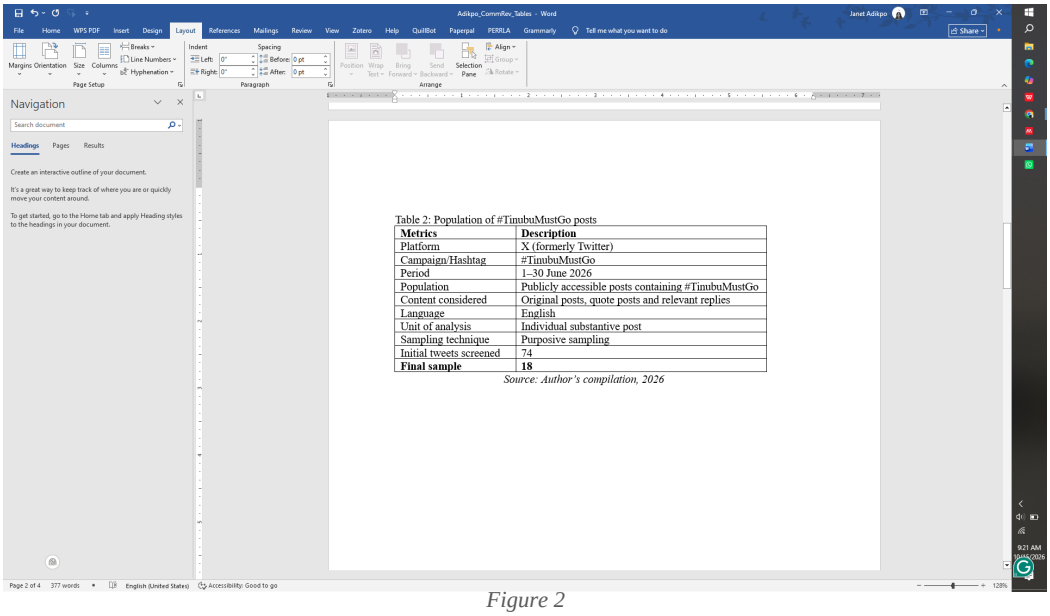


Table 2: Population of #TinubuMustGo posts

Metrics	**Description**
Platform	X (formerly Twitter)
Campaign/Hashtag	#TinubuMustGo
Period	1–30 June 2026
Population	Publicly accessible posts containing #TinubuMustGo
Content considered	Original posts, quote posts and relevant replies
Language	English
Unit of analysis	Individual substantive post
Sampling technique	Purposive sampling
Initial tweets screened	74
Final sample	**18**

Source: Author's compilation, 2026

Figure 2

Posts were analysed using deductive and inductive coding (Kuckartz & Rädiker, 2023). Deductive categories covered three dimensions: youth citizenship and political participation, digital activism and electoral mobilisation. Initial codes included political voice, accountability, agency, digital resistance, information sharing, calls to action, personalised political expression, electoral references and electoral mobilisation. Inductive coding identified additional patterns. Codes were compared across the 18 posts and grouped into themes.

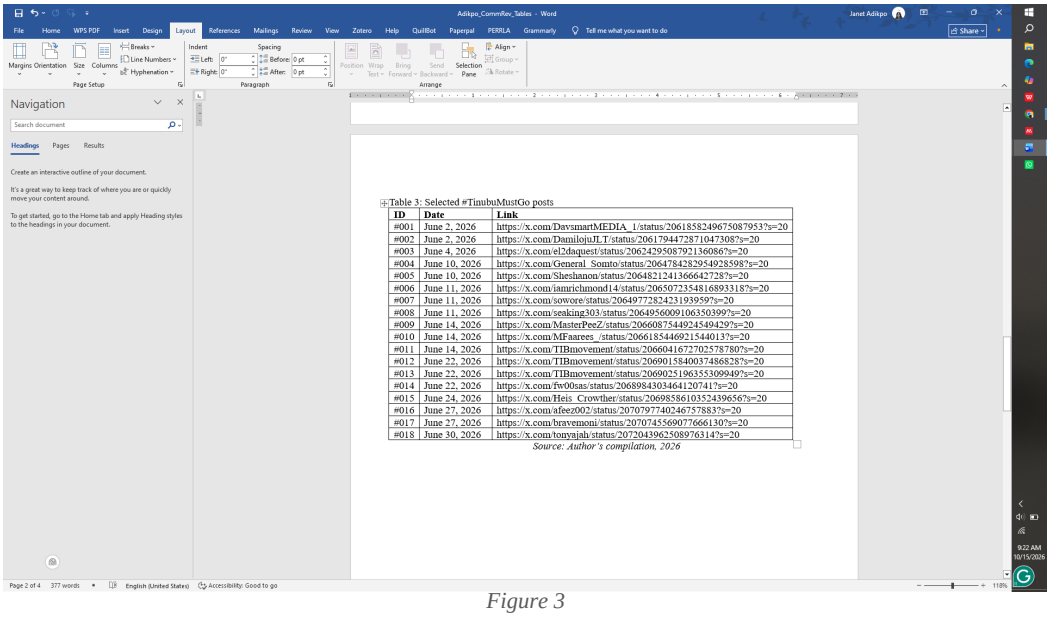


Table 3: Selected #TinubuMustGo posts

ID	Date	Link
#001	June 2, 2026	https://x.com/DavsmartMEDIA_1/status/2061858249675087953?s=20
#002	June 2, 2026	https://x.com/DamilojuJLT/status/2061794472871047308?s=20
#003	June 4, 2026	https://x.com/el2daguest/status/2062429508792136086?s=20
#004	June 10, 2026	https://x.com/General_Somto/status/2064784282954928598?s=20
#005	June 10, 2026	https://x.com/Sheshanon/status/2064821241366642728?s=20
#006	June 11, 2026	https://x.com/iamrichmond14/status/2065072354816893318?s=20
#007	June 11, 2026	https://x.com/sowore/status/2064977282423193959?s=20
#008	June 11, 2026	https://x.com/seaking303/status/2064956009106350399?s=20
#009	June 14, 2026	https://x.com/MasterPeeZ/status/2066087544924549429?s=20
#010	June 14, 2026	https://x.com/MFaarees_/status/2066185446921544013?s=20
#011	June 14, 2026	https://x.com/TIBmovement/status/2066041672702578780?s=20
#012	June 22, 2026	https://x.com/TIBmovement/status/2069015840037486828?s=20
#013	June 22, 2026	https://x.com/TIBmovement/status/2069025196355309949?s=20
#014	June 22, 2026	https://x.com/fw00sas/status/2068984303464120741?s=20
#015	June 24, 2026	https://x.com/Heis_Crowther/status/2069858610352439656?s=20
#016	June 27, 2026	https://x.com/afeez002/status/2070797740246757883?s=20
#017	June 27, 2026	https://x.com/bravemoni/status/2070745569077666130?s=20
#018	June 30, 2026	https://x.com/tonyajah/status/2072043962508976314?s=20

Source: Author's compilation, 2026

Figure 3

Connective action theory (Bennett & Segerberg, 2012) guided analysis of personalised political expressions within hashtag-mediated communication. The analysis examined personalised action frames, the hashtag's connective role, digitally networked mobilisation and whether governance-related expressions remained protest-oriented or acquired an electoral orientation. The coding guide was refined through repeated readings and cross-post comparison. To strengthen trustworthiness, coding decisions were checked against the original posts to ensure themes reflected the language and political claims. Electoral mobilisation was coded only when posts contained textual or visual evidence linking political expression to electoral participation. Only public posts were analysed and usernames, profile photographs and other identifying information were removed from reported data.

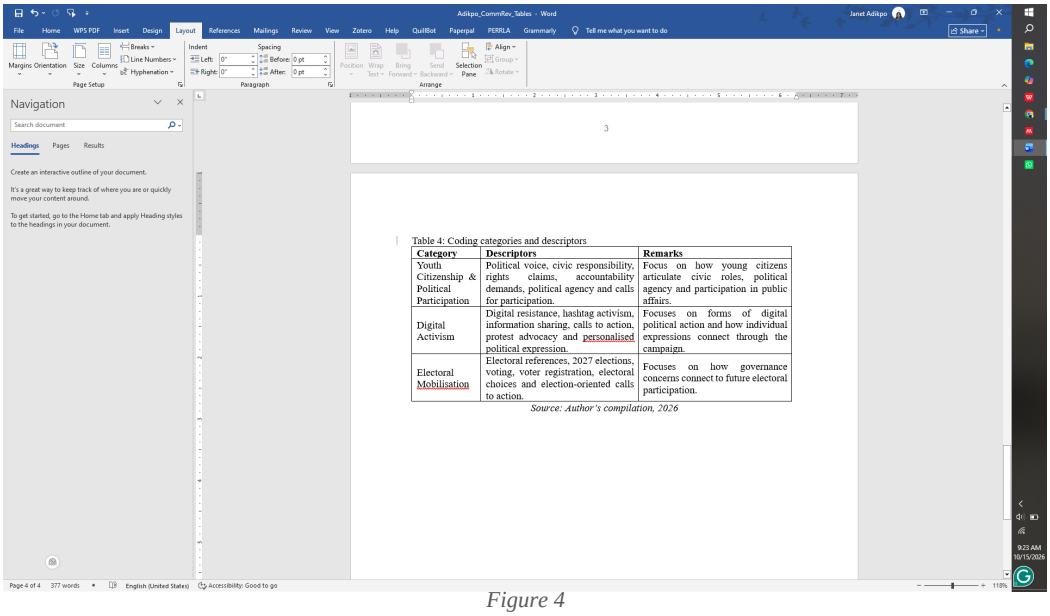


Table 4: Coding categories and descriptors

Category	Descriptors	Remarks
Youth Citizenship & Political Participation	Political voice, civic responsibility, rights claims, accountability demands, political agency and calls for participation.	Focus on how young citizens articulate civic roles, political agency and participation in public affairs.
Digital Activism	Digital resistance, hashtag activism, information sharing, calls to action, protest advocacy and personalised political expression.	Focuses on forms of digital political action and how individual expressions connect through the campaign.
Electoral Mobilisation	Electoral references, 2027 elections, voting, voter registration, electoral choices and election-oriented calls to action.	Focuses on how governance concerns connect to future electoral participation.

Source: Author's compilation, 2026

Figure 4

Findings and Analysis

Youth Citizenship through Political Voice and Accountability

The analysis reveals youth citizenship as active political engagement expressed through political voice,

accountability demands and claims about the State's responsibilities. These practices are evident in a post describing the #TinubuMustGo protest in Abuja:

"Nigerians are using their voices... In a democracy, protests remain one of the ways citizens make their feelings known."

The post constructs political voice as a democratic practice through which citizens communicate dissatisfaction. Through the #TinubuMustGo hashtag, this expression joins a wider stream of governance-related communication.

Political participation is also connected to political awareness. One tweet states:

"The fact that some people are still supporting Tinubu despite everything that's happening in Nigeria shows how messed up our situation is. There's a very huge awareness gap we need to bridge for us to have the country of our dream!"

The "awareness gap" frames political awareness as necessary for change, while "the country of our dream" connects individual judgement with a shared political future.

Accountability constitutes a second dimension. One tweet states that:

"20 killed in Kebbi. Another massacre. Another tragedy. Another reminder that the State is failing to protect its citizens. Nigerians deserve better."

The repeated "another" frames insecurity as an ongoing governance problem, while "Nigerians deserve better" expresses citizens' expectations of the State.

Another tweet broadens political authority:

"Seyi o, Must Go. Makinde, must go. Tinubu, must go. Useless, must go Enough of Playing politics with insecurity, the useless government that can't protect the people must leave. Be it president or governor. Be it IGP or COAS."

Naming different officeholders, the tweet distributes responsibility for insecurity across institutions and positions citizens to demand accountability from public authorities.

The discourse also connects citizenship with rights, evident in the assertion that:

"No prison is strong enough to silence the demand for justice. Freedom for the Nigerian people."

The language of "justice" and "freedom" constructs citizenship through rights claims, while "no prison is strong enough to silence" presents a political voice as persistent despite perceived constraints.

A further pattern concerns political agency:

"In case you missed this... #TinubuMustGo protest in Nyanya, Abuja. The day Nigerians decide to take back their country, all this political nonsense will end."

The phrase "take back their country" assigns agency to citizens, while its connection to the Nyanya protest links dissatisfaction with calls for political action. Overall, youth citizenship is constructed through political voice, awareness, rights claims, accountability and political agency.

Digital Activism through Hashtag Amplification and Protest Mobilisation

The analysis reveals digital activism as a networked practice through which political messages are amplified, participation is encouraged and protest coordination is promoted. A tweet shows hashtag amplification

directly:

"Hashtag tinubumustgo #tinubumustgo Push this hashtag guys"

The instruction to "push this hashtag" encourages users to increase campaign visibility.

A similar form of digital participation appears in another tweet:

"Everybody should #TINUBUMUSTRESIGN in the comments section it's take you nothing to re-tweet."

The expressions "everybody should" and "it's take you nothing to re-tweet" present commenting and reposting as low-threshold forms of participation.

Beyond amplification, the discourse uses digital platforms to mobilise participation in physical protest. One tweet states:

"Nigerians, when you wake up NATIONWIDE tomorrow, June 12 Democracy Day Action! TAKE CHARGE."

"NATIONWIDE" extends the call across locations, while "tomorrow" adds urgency to the appeal for protest participation.

More specific coordination is evident in another tweet:

"VDM said protests don't work - but last night, him and his "rats" proved otherwise. I love it. Join the movement: Abuja - join VDM Lagos - Friday, June 12, Ikeja Under Bridge No more silence. Demand accountability. End insecurity."

The tweet's date and location, along with the instruction to "join the movement", show how digital communication supports protest coordination across Abuja and Lagos. "No more silence" frames participation as a response to perceived government inaction.

Digital communication also circulates information about street-level action:

"Take It Back Movement protesters shut down Iwo Road, Ibadan this morning, demanding an end to insecurity and accountability over the ongoing kidnapping/abduction crisis."

Unlike the preceding calls to participate, this tweet reports an action. Sharing the Ibadan protest extends its visibility beyond those physically present and connects local action with the wider #TinubuMustGo discourse.

Another tweet uses the platform to recruit participants to an ongoing protest:

"Leave that club plan and meet us outside. Tinubu must go protest is on now in Abuja. We don't have a president and anybody occupying there who is clueless about running a nation, needs to get the hell out."

The informal instruction to "leave that club plan and meet us outside" redirects everyday activity towards protest. The phrase "protest is on now" adds urgency to the recruitment appeal.

Electoral Mobilisation through Governance Evaluation and Electoral Choice

The analysis shows electoral mobilisation as a process that links dissatisfaction with governance to future voting decisions. The connection is evident in a tweet reflecting on the economic situation:

"Looking back at this tweet. I don't think Nigerians are angry enough now add another 4 years. to your age.

Re-tweeted: The difference between 1 and $1 is so wild that even if you earn 1 every day, you still won't have $1 after 4 years."

The phrase "add another 4 years to your age" projects economic dissatisfaction into another electoral term, encouraging reflection on the consequences of political choices.

Another tweet links dissatisfaction more explicitly to political change:

"Tinubu has successfully failed Nigerians and it's ripe for Nigerians to kick him out.

Re-tweeted:

ENOUGH IS ENOUGH Tinubu Must Go! Nigerians are suffering badly and we can't continue like this. The hardship is too much and the promises are all lies. We want our country back! APC Must Go! Time to take our power back. Share if you're tired too."

Perceived hardship and dissatisfaction with government performance support the call to "kick him out". The instruction to "share if you're tired too" connects this demand to wider digital circulation.

Voting emerges more directly as a means of exercising agency in another tweet:

"BAT and his cohorts want to add akara to the cassava (garri) and corn he promised us last election. Collect the akara chop but VOTE your conscience. Our future is in our hands"

The "last election" links past campaign experiences to future electoral judgement. The instruction to "VOTE your conscience" presents voting as an individual decision, while "our future is in our hands" gives it collective significance.

The discourse becomes explicitly oriented towards re-election in the repeated appeal:

"Dear Nigerians Stop supporting Tinubu's re-election stop supporting Tinubu's re-election Stop supporting Tinubu's re-election He has failed. APC has been failing Nigeria."

The repetition adds urgency to the call against re-election and links the poster's evaluation of government performance to a future electoral decision.

The 2027 election is invoked in another post:

"VeryDarkMan Just Post This: 'RATEL Don Land. The message is clear: Bola Ahmed Tinubu is a failure and should not come back in 2027.'"

The phrase "should not come back in 2027" connects dissatisfaction with current leadership to the forthcoming election as an opportunity for political change.

This relationship between present experience and future voting is reinforced in the tweet:

"You can't hear all this and still proceed to vote for Tinubu.

People are going through it mehnn"

The tweet makes hardship relevant to voting decisions, presenting electoral choice as a response to prevailing social and economic conditions.

Electoral mobilisation within #TinubuMustGo connects economic hardship, perceived government failure and dissatisfaction with leadership to re-election and voting in 2027.

Discussion

The findings show how youth citizenship within #TinubuMustGo connects with digital activism and electoral mobilisation between elections. Youth citizenship is expressed through political voice, accountability

demands, rights claims and political agency, while digital activism provides networked practices through which these expressions circulate. Some expressions take on an explicit electoral orientation by linking dissatisfaction with government performance to voting, re-election, and the 2027 general elections.

The campaign's construction of youth citizenship supports scholarship that conceptualises citizenship beyond voting and party membership (Vromen et al., 2016). Political participation within #TinubuMustGo is reflected in posts that discuss governance, demand accountability, assert rights and encourage protest. These practices position citizens as political actors who evaluate the State and articulate expectations concerning security, justice and government responsiveness.

Researchers have identified similar forms of digitally mediated citizenship outside conventional political institutions (Loader et al., 2014; Choi, 2016). Recent Nigerian studies link youth activism to civic agency, political expression and governance concerns (Apata, 2025; Omilusi, 2025). Within the campaign, citizenship expressed in protest and accountability discourse connects to electoral politics when governance evaluations inform electoral choices.

Digital activism connects these forms of participation. While hashtag amplification, reposting, sharing, calls to action and protest coordination enable participants to contribute at different levels (Wang & Zhou, 2021), digital platforms reduce organisational barriers and allow dispersed individuals to support political causes through flexible engagement (Bennett & Segerberg, 2012). Evidence from Nigeria's #EndBadGovernance protests shows that social media facilitated protest coordination through digitally networked participation (Uwalaka et al., 2026). The use of digital communication to publicise and coordinate protest within #TinubuMustGo reflects a broader pattern in Nigerian digital activism.

Connective action theory helps explain how these practices form a political campaign. Bennett and Segerberg's (2012) concept of personalised action frames is relevant because the posts do not reproduce a single organisational message. Participants articulate dissatisfaction through concerns about insecurity, economic hardship, justice, political leadership and government accountability. #TinubuMustGo connects these contributions without requiring identical motivations or organisational membership. However, connectivity alone does not establish electoral mobilisation.

Scholarship on digital activism cautions against assuming that posting, sharing or hashtag participation necessarily produces sustained participation (Boulianne, 2020; Castillo-Esparcia et al., 2023). Much of #TinubuMustGo remains centered on governance concerns, accountability and protest. Nevertheless, a distinct strand explicitly refers to voting, re-election, electoral choice and 2027. The campaign therefore contains both connective political dissent and electorally oriented mobilisation. This distinction between connective political dissent and electorally oriented mobilisation clarifies how connective action theory applies to governance-focused digital activism between elections.

Digital communication links personalised grievances, but these can remain protest discourse or become electorally oriented when hardship, insecurity and perceived government failure are tied to voting choices. Egbunike (2025) documents how digital media and deprivation-related grievances intersected with the Obidient movement's electoral activities in 2023. Onayinka et al. (2026) likewise link #EndSARS activism, the Obidient movement and youth electoral participation.

The findings have practical implications for civic organisations, political communication practitioners and researchers. Hashtag activity should not be treated as evidence of electoral mobilisation without examining the messages. Governance-related posts may encourage public discussion, accountability demands or protest, while others explicitly call for electoral participation. Distinguishing these forms of engagement can help practitioners assess whether online campaigns encourage public debate, protest participation or electoral

action.

This study focuses on the period between national elections, when governance-focused activism may remain protest-oriented or acquire electoral meaning. The relationship should nevertheless be interpreted cautiously. Election-oriented messages within #TinubuMustGo does not demonstrate that digital participation will translate into voting behaviour or determine electoral outcomes. The findings identify electoral mobilisation at the level of political communication without inferring subsequent electoral behaviour.

Conclusion

This study examined youth citizenship, digital activism and electoral mobilisation through the #TinubuMustGo campaign ahead of Nigeria's 2027 general elections. The campaign provides a networked space where citizens demand accountability, exercise political voice and circulate governance concerns through hashtags, reposts, calls to action and protest mobilisation. Some expressions move beyond protest by linking government performance to voting, re-election and electoral choice.

Digital activism does not automatically become electoral mobilisation, although the two can intersect. Governance-related activism can remain centred on protest, accountability and resistance without an electoral orientation. Within #TinubuMustGo, however, some personalised grievances become electorally oriented when economic hardship, insecurity and perceived government failure are connected to voting decisions. Connective action theory helps explain how hashtag-mediated communication links personalised grievances without necessarily giving them an electoral orientation.

The study contributes to African political communication research by identifying the period between elections as a site of political participation. During this period, citizens evaluate governments, contest policies and articulate expectations about subsequent elections. #TinubuMustGo illustrates how digital platforms can connect civic activism, protest mobilisation and electoral communication between electoral cycles.

The study has limitations. Its focus on a single hashtag and platform captures only a segment of the wider political conversation. The qualitative analysis identifies patterns in public communication but cannot establish participants' demographic characteristics, motivations or whether online expressions translate into voting or other electoral behaviour. Future research could examine the campaign across platforms, incorporate interviews or surveys and follow its development towards the 2027 elections to assess whether digitally networked engagement develops into sustained electoral participation.

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